

ASTRO

THE ASTRALIS CODEX

The Five Houses · Edition II Lore Document



In the farthest reaches of the cosmos, where stardust weaves the fabric of fate, a galaxy stands on the edge of revelation. Ancient civilizations, cloaked for eons in cosmic mystery, stir from their slumber, their secrets echoing across time and space. Five great houses stand divided, each holding their truth — yet none knowing what truly waits beyond.

◆ PRIMA EXTRACTIO ◆

ANNO 2089

Internal Lore Bible · Confidential

FOREWORD

The Universe of Astro

The universe of **Astro** is built upon the conflict and coexistence of five great Houses. Each is not a nation nor a race, but a *philosophy* of relationship with Astro — the rare substance found only within the Void, the most coveted resource in the known galaxy.

They struggle for control over what is mined only in one place — and each interprets the substance through its own lens. None of the five are wholly righteous, and none are wholly evil. Each carries a **Light side** (public, noble, ceremonial) and a **Shadow side** (hidden, ruthless, true). It is a spectrum of moral grey — in the tradition of *Game of Thrones* and *Dune*.

Beyond their endless quarrels, a greater shadow looms — **The Architects**, the ancient creators of Astro itself, slowly returning from a forgotten age. None of the five Houses know they are coming. Only the Ophus Order suspects something stirs in the deep.

CONTENTS

I.	FEDERATION OF SOLAR SYSTEMS	<i>Federatio Solaris</i>
II.	HOUSE VORKHAN	<i>Domus Vorkhan</i>
III.	MERCANTI VERIS	<i>The Merchant Guild</i>
IV.	THE VERGENT	<i>Ordo Vergens</i>
V.	THE OPHUS ORDER	<i>Synodus Ophus</i>
VI.	SUMMARY · DRAMATURGICAL BALANCE	<i>Comparative analysis</i>
VII.	THE GREATER THREAT	<i>The Architects</i>

HOUSE I

FEDERATION OF SOLAR SYSTEMS

Federatio Solaris · The Federation

ARCHETYPE	Stark + Atreides + Star Trek Federation
ORGANIZATION	Political alliance of planetary systems
COLORS	Sky Azure (#4A90E2) (Light) · Deep Navy (#1A2F5A) (Shadow)

PHILOSOPHY

Guardians of order and scientific knowledge. They were the **first** to systematise the extraction of Astro from the Void and to establish protocols for its safe handling. They believe that access to Astro must be regulated, lawful, and just — for without order, civilization will tear itself apart in a war for the resource.

This is the most **sympathetic** of the five Houses — the 'good guys' of the universe: diplomatic, democratic, defenders of the weak. But sometimes *too cautious*. While they deliberate and debate, others act.

RELATION TO THE VOID

They **study and regulate** extraction. The Void is sacred and dangerous, demanding respect and protocol. The Federation maintains the strictest safety regulations for working with Astro of any House.

■ THE LIGHT SIDE

Parade orbital fleets, white ships with crystalline solar sails, diplomatic protocols, open scientific forums, democratic assemblies. The aesthetic of *NASA + Apple + Star Trek bridge* — clean, noble, optimistic.

SCIENTIA · CONCORDIA · PROGRESSIO

Knowledge · Concord · Progress

■ THE SHADOW SIDE

What hides behind the façade of order: covert intelligence networks, classified operations, hidden surveillance, black ships of observation. They **see everything** — even when they say they do not interfere. The truth of Federation power is the shadow it casts.

VIGILIA · SILENTIUM · IMPERIUM

Vigilance · Silence · Dominion

THE EMBLEM

A seven-pointed radiant star within a thin precise circle, bisected by a horizontal line. Rendered in metallic silver-gold.

- **Star** — Helios, the source of light and knowledge
- **Circle** — order, protocol, the unbroken cycle
- **Horizontal line** — the horizon of the Void, which they guard and study
- Stylistic principle: symmetry, fine lines, nobility, no sharp angles

PACKAGING AESTHETIC

- LIGHT** Warm parchment tones with golden detailing. Orbital diagrams, constellation lines, scenes of parade fleets. Illuminated manuscript feel.
- SHADOW** Deep navy metal plate with vibrant electric blue inner glow. Classified networks, dense technical schematics. Cinematic film-noir lighting.

HOUSE II

HOUSE VORKHAN

Domus Vorkhan · House Vorkhan

ARCHETYPE	Lannister + Harkonnen + Khorne (WH40K)
ORGANIZATION	Bloodline dynasty / military clan
COLORS	Crimson (#DC143C) (Light) · Blood (#5C0000) (Shadow)

PHILOSOPHY

A brutal warrior dynasty. They take Astro **by force**. They believe only the strong are worthy to touch the source — the weak deserve no voice in its fate. Their mines yield more than any other House because they do not flinch at losses, their own or others'.

The most **tense** of the Houses — but *not evil*. They live by a code of honour, ancestral nobility, fierce loyalty to clan. These are not mindless barbarians. They are aristocrats of war — like Vikings, like ancient horse-lords made cosmic.

RELATION TO THE VOID

They conquer access to the Void. Their philosophy is simple: those who can hold the source by force deserve it. They **raid** the deposits of other Houses, seize them, fortify them, defend them with iron will.

■ THE LIGHT SIDE

Parade armies, noble banners of warrior brotherhood, the aesthetics of knightly honour, rites of initiation, the warrior's code. The heroic side of war — like samurai epics. Parade ceremonies in the craters of dormant volcanoes, banners, ranks of gleaming weapons.

PUGNA · HONOR · IMPERIUM

Battle · Honour · Imperium

■ THE SHADOW SIDE

Bloody rituals, dark pacts, the cult of war without limits, the training of berserkers. Where Light shows the parade of honour — Shadow reveals the bloody rites of initiation, ritual ordeals, dark oaths sworn by torchlight. This is the *true* practice of war, hidden behind the parade façade.

MORS · PACTUM · VINDICTA

Death · Pact · Vengeance

THE EMBLEM

A cracked obsidian fist gripping a jagged lightning bolt.

- **Fist** — strength, grip, dominion
- **Obsidian** — black glass born of the Void (a hint of raw Astro)
- **Cracked** — they sacrifice themselves for power; scars are badges of valour

- **Lightning** — violence, speed, war, divine fury
- Stylistic principle: sharp angles, asymmetry, rough textures, military function

PACKAGING AESTHETIC

- LIGHT** Deep red with copper-gold accents. Mountain craters with rising flames, parade banners on pikes, weapons of honour displayed.
- SHADOW** Dark blood-red with vivid crimson flashes. Ritual circles, blood-fire, shadows of the fallen, bones, war as a sacred cult.

HOUSE III

MERCANTI VERIS

Mercanti Veris · 'The True Merchants' · The Mercanti

ARCHETYPE	Hanseatic League + Spacing Guild + Free Cities of Essos
ORGANIZATION	Intergalactic merchant guild (multi-species)
COLORS	Gold (#D4AF37) (Light) · Bronze (#6B4423) (Shadow)

PHILOSOPHY

A multi-species trading guild. **Not bound to any one nation or planet** — they are a *brand*, beneath which races from many worlds have gathered. They have endured for millennia, surviving empires and revolutions, because **trade is needed by all**.

Their philosophy: **commerce is above politics**. They sell Astro to everyone — the Federation, House Vorkhan, anyone who pays. They follow an ancient **code of merchant honour** — hence *Veris* (the True). A contract sealed by the Mercanti is sacred; to break it is to be hunted to the ends of the galaxy.

Morally grey. Not 'good' nor 'evil' — **pragmatic**. Charismatic anti-heroes.

RELATION TO THE VOID

They have no mines of their own. Instead, they own the **logistics** — they carry Astro between Houses. Their power lies in their **monopoly on the routes**. If House Vorkhan conquers the entire Void, they still need the Mercanti to deliver it.

■ THE LIGHT SIDE

Open orbital trading stations, golden interstellar routes, parade negotiations on neutral grounds, diplomatic agreements. The architecture of cosmic merchant palaces, transparent contracts — the *public* face of the guild.

LUCRO · FIDES · ITINERA

Profit · Faith · Pathways

■ THE SHADOW SIDE

Smuggling routes through hidden jump points, dark deals in orbital shadows, double agents, secret vaults, trade in *forbidden* goods (information, biological forms of Astro, Keeper intelligence). On the surface — a flawless guild. Beneath — a complex network of shadow commerce.

AURUM · UMBRA · CONTRACTUS

Gold · Shadow · Contract

THE EMBLEM

An eight-pointed **stellar compass** (a navigation rose for stars, NOT a maritime compass) within an orbital ring, with a central coin.

- **Eight directions** — they reach every corner of the galaxy

- **Orbital ring** — their network spans the worlds
- **Central coin** — commerce as the axis of their existence
- Stylistic principle: radial symmetry, elegant ornamentation, Latin filigree — the aesthetic of ancient astrolabes meets sci-fi

PACKAGING AESTHETIC

- LIGHT** Warm gold and parchment. Orbital trading stations around gas giants, sci-fi cargo vessels (NOT sailing ships), golden trade-line networks between stars, coins with cosmic symbols.
- SHADOW** Dark bronze with amber inner glow. Hidden cosmic smuggling routes glowing as golden veins through space, secret orbital vault stations.

HOUSE IV

THE VERGENT

Ordo Vergens · from 'verge' — the edge · The Vergent

ARCHETYPE

Bene Gesserit + Greenseers + Avatar Pandora + Annihilation

ORGANIZATION

Order of origin / biomancers

COLORS

Verdant Green (#00A86B) (Light) · Forest Moss (#1B3A1B) (Shadow)

PHILOSOPHY

Biomancers who treat Astro as **living matter**. They do not mine Astro in the traditional sense — they **cultivate** it. They have learned to grow Astro within living organisms through symbiosis.

The name *Vergent* means '**those who stand on the edge**' — between life and Astro, between nature and science, between human and **something more**.

The most **enigmatic** faction. Neither evil nor good — *other*. Their motives elude the others: do they value life, evolution, or something deeper that no one else can yet perceive?

RELATION TO THE VOID

Unique. They **descend into the Void** not to extract but to gather *specimens* — crystalline forms of Astro which they then **plant** in their biospheres. From these specimens grow **hybrid forms** — plants and creatures, part Astro, part living. This yields *less* resource, but *purier* and stranger.

■ THE LIGHT SIDE

Bioluminescent gardens on their home worlds, healing laboratories, hybrid plants, symbiotic creatures, the aesthetic of **living beauty** drawn from Astro. Here the Vergent are *life-savers*, cultivators of wonders.

CONIVNCTIO · EVOLVTIO · UNITAS

Connection · Evolution · Unity

■ THE SHADOW SIDE

Infected jungles, root-vaults of forbidden specimens, mutations beyond control, **eyes upon the branches**, parasitic forms, biological experiments on captives. Here the Vergent are *not evil* — but they **play with fire**, and sometimes the fire wins. This is where symbiosis becomes *absorption*, and cultivation becomes *distortion*.

RADIX · OBSCURUM · GENESIS

Root · Darkness · Genesis

THE EMBLEM

A tight geometric spiral coiling inward to a small almond-shaped eye at its centre.

- **Spiral** — DNA, growth, evolution, life, inward draw
- **Eye at the centre** — living consciousness watching from within; a hint that their Astro *looks back*

- Stylistic principle: organic asymmetry, bioluminescent accents — like a Japanese kamon, an order's banner, NOT a botanical illustration

PACKAGING AESTHETIC

- LIGHT** Deep verdant green with golden-emerald accents. Bioluminescent cosmic tree, branches with planet-leaves, glowing fruit, symbiotic patterns.
- SHADOW** Dark moss with vivid emerald bio-flashes. Mutated tree, glowing fruit-eyes, roots penetrating dark matter, parasitic forms.

HOUSE V

THE OPHUS ORDER

Synodus Ophus · The Ophus

ARCHETYPE	Bene Gesserit + Mentat + Lovecraft cult + Doctor Strange order
ORGANIZATION	Mystical religious order
COLORS	Amethyst (#9966CC) (Light) · Violet Void (#2A0040) (Shadow)

PHILOSOPHY

Mystics who use Astro for **mental connection and prophecy**. Their great temple stands on **Ophus Prime**. They believe Astro is a **language** through which *something* speaks to them from the depths of the Void.

They **descend** into the Void not to extract but to **commune**. Many of their ranks **change** from this — gradually becoming not quite human. They are the *strangest* of the Houses, but the most powerful in matters of the mind.

Unlike the others, the Ophus Order **suspects** something of The Architects. They **hear** whispers, see dreams, receive visions. They do not know *what* is approaching — but they feel that **it** is coming.

RELATION TO THE VOID

The deepest and most dangerous of all. They **descend into the Void** further than any other. They **listen**, they **hear**, and sometimes they **answer**. Their priests (the Augurs), after long meditation in the Void, often return with **information that should not have been knowable**.

■ THE LIGHT SIDE

Enlightened halls of the order, libraries of secret knowledge, meditative rituals, golden scrolls of prophecy, oracular practices, the aesthetic of **noble mysticism**. Here the Ophus are *sages*, advising the Federation, interpreting dreams, helping others find meaning.

VERITAS · OCCVLTA · TRANSFORMATIO

Truth · Hidden · Transformation

■ THE SHADOW SIDE

Occult communion chambers, rituals of direct contact with the Void, **dark knowledge**, the cult of the listeners. Here the Ophus are those who have *gone too far*. They are no longer fully human. They **know** what should not be known. And they **serve** something that has not yet arrived.

ABYSSUS · MYSTERIUM · DOMINATIO

Abyss · Mystery · Dominion

THE EMBLEM

An inverted equilateral triangle, pointing downward, containing an open eye. In place of a normal pupil — a many-pointed radiant star. The whole composition enclosed within a circular order seal bearing ritual symbols.

- **Inverted triangle** — the gate, the descent into the Void, the path to the source

- **Open eye** — knowledge, vision, *perhaps* madness
- **Many-pointed star pupil** — they see what should not be seen
- **Order seal** — ritual, hierarchy, mystical brotherhood
- Stylistic principle: sacred geometry, distorted symmetry, occult proportions — the eye must *watch* the viewer

PACKAGING AESTHETIC

- LIGHT** Deep amethyst with silver-gold accents. Sacred geometry mandalas in cosmic space, oracle chambers with shafts of light, open scrolls, meditative symbols.
- SHADOW** Deep violet, near-black, with vivid amethyst flashes. Occult chambers, communion altars to the Void, rituals by candlelight, eyes in darkness, cracks in reality, whispers of the Architects as glowing trails.

VI

Summary · Dramaturgical Balance

A complete picture of the five Houses, arranged from most sympathetic to most morally tense. Each occupies its own niche in the moral spectrum of the Astralis universe.

HOUSE	COLORS	VOID RELATION	MOTTO (LIGHT)
FEDERATION	Sky Azure / Navy	Study & regulate	SCIENTIA · CONCORDIA
HOUSE VORKHAN	Crimson / Blood	Conquer by force	PUGNA · HONOR
MERCANTI VERIS	Gold / Bronze	Control logistics	LUCRO · FIDES
THE VERGENT	Verdant / Moss	Cultivate Astro	CONIVNCTIO · UNITAS
THE OPHUS ORDER	Amethyst / Violet	Hear the Architects	VERITAS · OCCVLTA

THE MORAL SPECTRUM

Most Sympathetic · *Light side dominant*

FEDERATION OF SOLAR SYSTEMS — noble guardians of order, scientific protocol, diplomatic restraint. Sometimes too cautious — while they deliberate, others act.

Morally Grey · *Equal Light and Shadow*

MERCANTI VERIS — pragmatic traders, charismatic anti-heroes. Sell to all sides. Honour their contracts but ask no moral questions.

THE VERGENT — biomancers playing with the fire of life. Healers and creators, but their experiments do not always end well.

Morally Tense · *Shadow leaning, but never simply evil*

HOUSE VORKHAN — closest to a 'dark' faction, but bound by an ironclad code of warrior honour. Brutal, but never dishonourable.

THE OPHUS ORDER — the strangest. Walking the edge of human existence. They hear what should not be heard. The first to suspect what is coming.

This balance creates a true spectrum — not a binary morality. Every reader and every collector will find their own House by character.

VII

The Greater Threat

THE ARCHITECTS

The makers of Astro. The reason none of the five Houses are truly safe.

An ancient civilization, vanished from the galaxy thousands of years before humans first reached the stars. They created Astro — perhaps as a tool, perhaps as a byproduct, perhaps as a weapon. None of the five Houses know.

Now, slowly, they are **returning**.

Only the Ophus Order suspects something. The whispers in the Void grow louder. The dreams of their seers grow sharper. Yet even they do not comprehend the scale.

STORYTELLING NOTES

The Architects are the **final antagonist** of the saga. They reveal themselves *gradually*, edition by edition, never directly named in Edition II. Only hints in the Transmission Logs — a word, a coordinate, an unexplained symbol.

When the five Houses inevitably realize the truth, they will face an impossible choice: continue their ancient quarrel, or unite against something none of them can defeat alone.

This is the long-term arc of the Astro universe. It belongs to the future. For now — let the five Houses rise.

◆ END OF CODEX ◆

This is the legend of Astro — a universe of endless wonder, ancient power, and cosmic peril. Where every journey begins with a spark, and ends among the stars.